

PRIVATE RESEARCH MEMORANDUM

Choosing a K–8 School for the Age of Machine Intelligence

*A liberal-arts framework and evidence review for River’s first-grade
placement, New Orleans, 2027–28*

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SUBJECT	Homer Plessy 7th Ward vs. International School of Louisiana
DECISION WINDOW	NCAP Main Round opens 2 November 2026
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Note on evidence. Assessment figures in Section V were extracted directly from the Louisiana Department of Education’s published *School LEAP Mastery Summary* and *K–3 Literacy Screener* files rather than from third-party aggregators, whose figures for these schools lag by two to three years. All external claims are hyperlinked to primary or peer-reviewed sources.

Executive Summary

The governing question is not which New Orleans school has adapted to artificial intelligence. None has, in any way that survives scrutiny. The question is which school builds the capacities that hold their value when routine cognitive output becomes cheap: close reading of difficult text, writing as an instrument of thought, quantitative reasoning, source discernment, and taste.

Those capacities describe the classical liberal arts curriculum. That is a strategic advantage rather than a limitation: it removes the need to forecast correctly. An education built on books, mathematics, argument, and the arts pays out whether or not the labor market transforms on schedule.

Two schools were examined in depth: **Homer Plessy Community School (7th Ward campus)**, the incumbent, and **International School of Louisiana (St. Roch campus)**, the leading alternative. A third, **Audubon Charter School’s Montessori track**, remains the strongest philosophical match but carries the longest admissions odds in the city.

Principal findings

- **Plessy runs the better curriculum on paper.** Wit & Wisdom, Illustrative Mathematics, Amplify Science, and daily dance, music, theater and visual art constitute the strongest liberal-arts alignment available tuition-free in the city.
- **Plessy’s foundational reading deteriorates through the grades.** On Louisiana’s spring 2026 K–3 literacy screener it moves from 58.6% at kindergarten to **48.5% at third grade**, fifteen points below the state and eleven below its own district.
- **ISL pays a steep early cost, then clears the benchmark.** Its kindergarteners register 22.8% on that screener, a direct consequence of immersion; by third grade they reach **68.3%**, above the state average. Its five-year mathematics gain, +18 points, is the largest in the comparison set.
- **Plessy is not moving its students.** Economically disadvantaged students fell from 24% to 23% year over year; students with disabilities have been flat at 11% for two years. ISL gained six points in the same subgroup.
- **ISL subordinates curriculum to language.** Kindergarten and first grade run approximately 90% in French or Spanish; English Language Arts begins in second grade, sixty minutes daily.
- **Plessy operates a 1:1 device program from first grade.** Confirmed directly; devices remain on campus. Integration detail has been requested and is pending. ISL’s policy remains undisclosed.

RECOMMENDATION IN BRIEF

Rank ISL above Plessy in the NCAP main round, with Audubon Montessori first as the high-value reach. Retain Plessy as an informed fallback contingent on a single question: what structured foundational-skills program does it run in grades K–2, and how does it account for a third-grade screener result eleven points below its own district?

SCORECARD — FINALISTS AGAINST THE STATED CRITERIA

Criterion	Plessy — 7th Ward	ISL — St. Roch	Audubon — Montessori
Liberal-arts curriculum design	STRONG Wit & Wisdom, Illustrative Math	WEAK organized around language	ADEQUATE materials-led inquiry
Foundational literacy outcomes	WEAK 48.5% at grade 3	ADEQUATE 68.3% at grade 3	STRONG 82.5% at grade 3
Five-year trajectory	ADEQUATE math up, ELA flat	STRONG +10 ELA, +18 math	STRONG +6 ELA, +19 math
Arts as core provision	STRONG daily, four disciplines	WEAK enrichment block	ADEQUATE integrated
Low-device pedagogy	WEAK 1:1 from grade 1, in-school	ADEQUATE oral method; policy unknown	STRONG materials-based
Commute from 70115	STRONG incumbent	STRONG +3–6 min	STRONG Uptown
Admission probability	STRONG rolling; enrolled	ADEQUATE non-selective	WEAK heavily oversubscribed

Ratings are the author’s synthesis of the evidence in Sections III–V, weighted to the criteria stated in Section II. Audubon figures are included for reference; it is treated as a reach application rather than a finalist.

SECTION II

The Premise and What It Implies for Curriculum

If machine intelligence commoditizes competent routine output — drafting, summarizing, first-pass analysis, boilerplate code — the durable capacities are those that direct such output rather than produce it. Judgment about which questions are worth asking. The ability to read a difficult argument closely enough to find its weak joint. Writing well enough to think clearly. Mathematics deep enough to know when a number is lying. Taste, meaning a trained sense of quality that can be articulated and defended.

None of this is novel pedagogy. It is the liberal arts curriculum, taught for centuries. The practical consequence for school selection is counterintuitive but firm:

SELECTION PRINCIPLE

A school that markets “AI readiness,” one-to-one devices, or a technology-forward brand is providing evidence *against* alignment, not for it. The correct signal is a school that teaches whole books, sustained writing, real mathematics, and the arts, and that treats screens as an occasional tool rather than an organizing principle.

A second consequence concerns higher education. If the credential value of a degree erodes while the formation value persists, the argument for building demonstrable capability and portfolio early — rather than optimizing an admissions résumé — strengthens considerably. That argues for depth over breadth in the K–8 years, and for institutions that produce work rather than scores.

SECTION III

Classroom Technology: What the Evidence Supports

One-to-one device provision is now the elementary norm. An [EdWeek Research Center survey](#) found roughly 40% of district leaders provided a device for every elementary student before the pandemic; by March 2021, 84% did. Ubiquity is not evidence of efficacy.

WHAT THE LITERATURE HOLDS

- The [NAEYC and Fred Rogers Center position statement](#) holds that technology should enhance without replacing creative play, physical activity, outdoor experience, conversation and social interaction. The harm is framed as displacement, not exposure.
- UNESCO’s [2023 Global Education Monitoring Report](#) found benefits disappear when technology is used in excess or without a qualified teacher, and that distributing computers does not improve learning absent teacher involvement. Across seventeen U.S. states, only 11% of educators consulted peer-reviewed evidence before adopting an educational technology.
- A meta-analysis of [39 studies and 1,812 children aged one to eight](#) found lower comprehension for digital books when medium was the only variable, and adult mediation during print reading outperformed digital enhancements read independently.
- An EEG study in [Frontiers in Psychology](#) found markedly greater brain connectivity during handwriting than typing, prompting its authors to argue for a handwriting minimum in the lower grades. It used university students and has drawn published methodological objection; treat as suggestive.

THE MECHANISM THAT MATTERS MOST

The sharpest finding for a parent concerned about “worker” versus “author” formation is the *use* divide. [Warschauer and colleagues](#) documented that once access is equalized, application diverges by class: lower-SES students are directed toward drill and individualized practice while higher-SES students conduct research and analysis. Later work confirms that schools serving more marginalized students offer fewer opportunities for transformative digital learning at comparable access.

IMPLICATION FOR EVALUATION

Device count is a weak variable; instructional model is a strong one. The diligence question at any school tour is not whether children use laptops but what they do on them, for how many minutes, and whether that time supplements or substitutes for teacher-led instruction.

Candidate Comparison: Pedagogy and Curriculum

TABLE 1 — STRUCTURAL AND PEDAGOGICAL COMPARISON

	Homer Plessy — 7th Ward	ISL — St. Roch
Campus / transition	PreK4–4th, 1651 N. Tonti St.; Tremé for 5–8	K–3rd, 2518 Arts St.; Camp St. (LGD) for 4–8
Organizing model	Arts-integrated, project-based	Language immersion, French or Spanish
ELA	Wit & Wisdom	Target-language arts; English ELA from grade 2, 60 min/day
Math / science	Illustrative Mathematics; Amplify Science	Both taught in target language
Arts	Daily dance, music, theater, visual art; strings and band at Tremé	Art, music, PE as enrichment block
Admission	Type 1 charter; no testing	Non-selective; language proficiency required after 1 Sept, grade 1
Daily hours	8:00–3:00 (Wed 2:00)	8:00–3:30 (Wed 2:30)
Device posture	1:1 from grade 1; devices stay on campus	Undisclosed

Plessy: the stronger curriculum on paper

Plessy publishes its instructional materials, itself a mark of confidence. [Wit & Wisdom](#) is among the most explicitly liberal-arts English curricula in American use: students work with complex grade-level books from classics to contemporary literature, and fine art is woven into every module as a subject of close examination. It holds top EdReports ratings and a Louisiana Tier 1 designation for all grades K–8. One fourth-grade module, per the [Massachusetts CURATE review](#), interweaves the novel *Love That Dog*, an informational text on the circulatory system, poems by Frost and Walter Dean Myers, and biographies of historical figures. Illustrative Mathematics is likewise problem-based and discourse-driven rather than procedural.

STRUCTURAL CAVEAT

Wit & Wisdom teaches students to read *to learn*. Its publisher states plainly that it does not systematically teach the youngest students to *learn to read*, and recommends pairing it with a separate research-based foundational-skills program. What Plessy uses for that half is not published. Section V suggests the question is material.

ISL: curriculum subordinated to language

ISL publishes no comparable materials list. Its [curriculum statement](#) holds that Louisiana standards provide the framework and that the test applied to every curricular decision is whether it fulfills the immersion mission — explicitly not whether a resource is strong on its merits. The progression is steep: roughly 90% of daily instruction in the target language in kindergarten and first grade, only enrichment possibly in English; roughly 80% in grades two through five, English Language Arts added at sixty minutes daily; roughly 25% in middle school.

The research is reassuring but conditional. [Genesee and Lindholm-Leary’s synthesis](#) finds immersion students reach competence in non-language subjects equal to mainstream peers, including under early total immersion — but conditions parity on assessment in the second language with allowance for incomplete acquisition. Louisiana’s LEAP is in English. Closing that gap is ISL’s central task, and Section V indicates it is being closed.

Reference case: Audubon Charter Montessori

Audubon serves as benchmark throughout: the only tuition-free school in the city whose pedagogy matches the Section III principle without qualification — hands-on materials, extended work periods, mixed-age classrooms, no dependence on screens — and the strongest performer of the three in Section V. The constraint is access: demand has run near 1,200 applications against roughly 171 Montessori seats, and an entry assessment applies from grade three, leaving grades one and two the only untested window.

DEVICE POSTURE — PARTIALLY RESOLVED

Plessy’s one-to-one program was confirmed directly; integration detail pending. On-campus retention is meaningful mitigation — per Section III the open variable is application, not possession. ISL’s policy is undisclosed; its oral K–1 method argues against heavy use, but that is inference, not stated policy.

SECTION V

Outcome Evidence

TABLE 2 — LEAP % MASTERY AND ABOVE, GRADES 3–8, FIVE-YEAR TREND

School	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026	Δ
Homer Plessy — ELA	34	38	41	43	41	+7
ISL — ELA	52	53	59	56	62	+10
Audubon — ELA	63	64	66	70	69	+6
Louisiana — ELA	—	—	—	43	43	0
Homer Plessy — Math	19	20	22	25	27	+8
ISL — Math	35	39	42	46	53	+18
Audubon — Math	32	41	43	49	51	+19
Louisiana — Math	—	—	—	33	34	+1

LDOE School LEAP Mastery Summary, 2023–2026 releases. Plessy’s ELA has plateaued and reversed over three cycles while its mathematics improves steadily; ISL’s mathematics gain is the largest here.

TABLE 3 — K–3 LITERACY SCREENER, SPRING 2026: % READING ON OR ABOVE GRADE LEVEL

School	Overall	Kinder	Grade 1	Grade 2	Grade 3
Homer Plessy	58.5	58.6	69.6	56.9	48.5
Int’l School of Louisiana	44.9	22.8	39.8	59.4	68.3
Audubon Charter	75.9	71.6	69.3	81.0	82.5
Orleans Parish	65.7	73.5	68.1	62.2	59.4
Louisiana statewide	66.2	69.0	67.5	64.4	64.0

LDOE 2025–26 EOY K–3 Literacy Screener. Measures foundational reading — decoding and phonics — the most direct evidence available on this question.

THE DECISIVE FINDING

The schools trace opposite curves. ISL begins at 22.8% because it is not yet teaching English reading, then climbs to 68.3% by third grade, above the state benchmark. Plessy begins near average and *declines* to 48.5%. Foundational reading is consolidating at one school and eroding at the other.

Context. Louisiana has run Mississippi’s play and it has worked. State law requires all K–3 teachers and administrators to complete approved professional development in phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary and comprehension grounded in the science of reading. On the 2024 NAEP, Louisiana fourth graders were the only cohort in the country to exceed pre-pandemic reading performance, and the state now ranks *second nationally for low-income fourth-grade reading*. Two qualifications: the state describes its strategy as rejecting the false choice between foundational skills and content-rich curriculum, investing in both; and the approach has a documented ceiling, since *those fourth-grade gains have not carried to eighth grade*. Phonics carries a child to third grade; knowledge-building carries them from fourth to eighth. Plessy has the second half and, on this evidence, may lack the first.

TABLE 4 — SUBGROUP PERFORMANCE, % MASTERY+ ALL SUBJECTS, 2025 → 2026

Subgroup	Plessy	ISL	Audubon
Economically disadvantaged	24 → 23	31 → 37	40 → 45
Not economically disadvantaged	54 → 51	54 → 57	65 → 66
Black students	15 → 17	36 → 35	35 → 39
White students	58 → 58	63 → 67	70 → 72
Students with disabilities	11 → 11	23 → 29	35 → 41

LDOE 2026 School LEAP Mastery Subgroup Summary. Plessy carries a 41-point internal gap between white and Black students and a 28-point gap by income, with both halves flat or falling. River’s own subgroup scores 58 at Plessy against the school’s headline 41 — and 67 at ISL, 72 at Audubon.

Recommendations

1 Rank ISL above Plessy in the NCAP main round.

The curriculum argument favors Plessy; the evidence on children's actual reading favors ISL decisively. A program that is losing ground on foundational literacy through third grade cannot deliver the liberal-arts outcome its materials promise, however good those materials are. Suggested order: **(1) Audubon Montessori — (2) ISL St. Roch — (3) The Willow School — (4) Lake Forest Elementary — (5) Plessy 7th Ward**. Use all twelve available rankings; the algorithm can only match against schools listed.

2 Put one diagnostic question to Plessy, verbatim.

"What structured foundational-skills program do you use in grades K–2, who on staff is trained in it, and how do you account for a third-grade literacy screener result of 48.5% against a district figure of 59.4%?" A ready, specific answer reopens Plessy as a genuine contender. Absence of one settles the matter.

3 Verify three things at ISL before ranking.

Confirm the first-grade language requirement in writing, since proficiency becomes mandatory for applicants after 1 September of the first-grade year. Ask what English foundational-skills instruction, if any, occurs before grade two. Ask how the 3:30 dismissal and the grade-four campus transition to Camp Street are handled operationally.

4 Apply to Waldorf School of New Orleans in parallel.

It is the only school in the city where minimal technology is stated pedagogy rather than concession, and the only one that satisfies the Section III principle without argument. It publishes no assessment data, which is a real cost; treat it as a hedge rather than a primary, and confirm current tuition and campus directly.

5 Close the technology question at ISL as Plessy's has been closed.

Plessy is now known to run one-to-one devices from grade one, on campus only, with integration detail pending. Put the identical three questions to ISL — daily minutes, specific programs, and whether screen time supplements or substitutes for teacher-led instruction. Per Section III these are the variables the research turns on, and the comparison is only meaningful if both answers are in hand. Note that Trinity Episcopal, a strong private alternative, markets one-to-one iPads from first grade as an included feature.

6 Treat the home as the primary site for taste and discernment.

No New Orleans school will deliver the full brief. The reading, argument, and aesthetic judgment described in Section II are built substantially outside school hours, and that portion is not subject to a lottery.

Decision triggers

- **2 November 2026** — NCAP main round opens; rankings due in January. Tour Audubon, ISL, and Waldorf before this date.
- **Reconsider Plessy upward** if it names a credible structured phonics program and its 2027 screener shows third-grade recovery above the district figure.
- **Reconsider Plessy downward** if the subgroup gaps widen again or the charter renewal recommendation this December is unfavorable.
- **Audubon remains the ceiling.** Grades 1–2 are the only untested Montessori entry point; from grade 3 an assessment applies. This window closes in two years.

SOURCES

1. Louisiana Department of Education, [Elementary and Middle School Performance](#) data files, 2022–2026.
2. Homer Plessy Community Schools, [FAQ and Policies](#).
3. International School of Louisiana, [Curriculum](#) and [About ISL](#).
4. Great Minds, [Wit & Wisdom](#); Massachusetts DESE, [CURATE](#) review.
5. NAEYC & Fred Rogers Center, [Technology and Interactive Media in Early Childhood](#).
6. UNESCO, [GEM Report 2023: Technology in Education](#).
7. Furenes, Kucirkova & Bus, "Children's Reading on Paper Versus Screen," *Rev. Educ. Res.* 91(4).
8. Van der Weel & Van der Meer, [Frontiers in Psychology](#) 14:1219945.
9. Warschauer & Matuchniak, "New Technology and Digital Worlds," *Rev. Res. Educ.* 34(1).
10. Genesee & Lindholm-Leary, [Student Outcomes in Language Immersion Education](#).
11. Hechinger Report, "Why the Mississippi Miracle Disappears by Eighth Grade."
12. The Lens, [2025 School Performance Scores](#).